

CITIZENS OF HEAVEN

ANDY SNOKE

"For our citizenship is in heaven, from which we also eagerly wait for the Savior, the Lord Jesus Christ" (Philippians 3:20, NKJV).

Dr. Ryrie comments as follows regarding the verse above: "Paul wants the church in Philippi to beware of *"enemies of the cross of Christ"* (Philippians 3:17-19), whose end is final judgment. By contrast, *"our citizenship is in heaven"* (v. 20). Philippi, a city in Macedonia, many miles from Rome, enjoyed the status of a Roman colony, including privileges of Roman citizenship. Even as the Philippians, far from Rome, had Roman citizenship, so believers, far from heaven, hold citizenship there."

I appreciate this short commentary on this verse. Philippi, located in Greece, was made up of a Roman colony, and many now believed in Christ. They enjoyed the benefits of Roman citizenship as they were a colony of Rome, although Rome was far, far away. They politically belonged to a country that they did not live in—that is, Rome. They lived in Philippi, but they were citizens of Rome. They lived and died by the laws of Rome. They followed the laws and traditions of Rome. They lived on the "bread" of Rome, though Rome was far away.

It was appropriate for Paul to remind the Philippians that they had citizenship from "another country," from heaven. They were familiar with the concept of belonging to a country and the government of a land they did not live in. When Paul mentioned that their citizenship was in heaven, it must have made immediate sense to them. It was not a foreign concept.

They lived and breathed in Philippi, but they learned that they lived and died according to the truths, norms, and life that come from heaven.

Their life came from Jesus Christ, not the bread of Rome, but the bread of heaven. Their salvation and forgiveness came from the blood of the cross. They had a new citizenship—an eternal citizenship that could not be ended by death. They were not part of this world, for their citizenship was in heaven.

Before this verse, Paul warns Philippi about false teachers. It is believed that Paul is most likely speaking against a false teaching noted as "Libertine," which was essentially the:

1. Discarding moral laws.
2. Trusting their human wisdom.
3. Denying the transforming power of the Gospel.
4. Saving themselves by following their own laws (legalism).

These insidious, cancerous doctrines have crept into the church throughout the ages in one form or another. As with the church in Philippi, we must stand on guard today against these dangers.

Paul notes that, *"whose end is destruction, whose god is their belly, and whose glory is in their shame—who set their mind on earthly things"* (Philippians 3:19, NKJV).

This reference is for those whose lives have become completely earthly and sensual. Their happiness is based on what they can see, eat, taste, do, and possess. Those *"whose god is their belly"* are those who have made the "world" their citizenship, who have set their minds on earthly things.

Let me print the entire text for reference, *“Brethren, join in following my example, and note those who so walk, as you have us for a pattern. For many walk, of whom I have told you often, and now tell you even weeping, that they are the enemies of the cross of Christ: whose end is destruction, whose god is their belly, and whose glory is in their shame—who set their mind on earthly things. **For our citizenship is in heaven, from which we also eagerly wait for the Savior, the Lord Jesus Christ, who will transform our lowly body that it may be conformed to His glorious body, according to the working by which He is able even to subdue all things to Himself**”* (Philippians 3:17-21, NKJV).

By contrast, we are to place our affections and thoughts on our new citizenship in heaven, not on earth.

“If then you were raised with Christ, seek those things which are above, where Christ is, sitting at the right hand of God. 2 Set your mind on things above, not on things on the earth” (Colossians 3:1-2, NKJV).

Paul does not leave us “hanging” but gives us good practical advice on how people that are “citizens of heaven” should spend their time thinking and acting. That is one of the things I appreciate about the Scriptures; it gives much practical advice on how to live.

“Rejoice in the Lord always. Again I will say, rejoice! Let your gentleness be known to all men. The Lord is at hand. Be anxious for nothing, but in everything by prayer and supplication, with thanksgiving, let your requests be made known to God; and the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and minds through Christ Jesus. Meditate on These Things. Finally, brethren, whatever things are true, whatever things are noble, whatever things are just, whatever things are pure, whatever things are lovely, whatever things are of good report, if there is any virtue and if there is anything praiseworthy—meditate on these things” (Philippians 4:4-8, NKJV).

In writing to the Colossians, Paul also offers much practical advice on thinking and living. We would do well to take our time, read these slowly, and apply them to our daily lives.

“If then you were raised with Christ, seek those things which are above, where Christ is, sitting at the right hand of God. Set your mind on things above, not on things on the earth. For you died, and your life is hidden with Christ in God. When Christ who is our life appears, then you also will appear with Him in glory. Therefore put to death your members which are on the earth: fornication, uncleanness, passion, evil desire, and covetousness, which is idolatry. Because of these things the wrath of God is coming upon the sons of disobedience, in which you yourselves once walked when you lived in them. But now you yourselves are to put off all these: anger, wrath, malice, blasphemy, filthy language out of your mouth. Do not lie to one another, since you have put off the old man with his deeds, and have put on the new man who is renewed in knowledge according to the image of Him who created him, where there is neither Greek nor Jew, circumcised nor uncircumcised, barbarian, Scythian, slave nor free, but Christ is all and in all. Character of the New Man. Therefore, as the elect of God, holy and beloved, put on tender mercies, kindness, humility, meekness, longsuffering; bearing with one another; and forgiving one another, if anyone has a complaint against another; even as Christ forgave you, so you also must do. But above all these things put on love, which is the bond of perfection. And let the peace of God rule in your hearts, to which also you were called in one body; and be thankful. Let the word of Christ dwell in you richly in all wisdom, teaching and admonishing one another in psalms and hymns and spiritual songs, singing with grace in your hearts to the Lord. And whatever you do in word or deed, do all in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks to God the Father through Him” (Colossians 3:1-17, NKJV).

Letter to Diognetus

The pages of history tell us that the early Christians indeed left a

testimony of living their lives as if **citizens of heaven**, as Paul exhorts.

This famous work of literature, dated about the 2nd or 3rd century, was written by an unknown author to a person named Diognetus. Diognetus, most likely a pagan dignitary, appeared to want to know more about the peculiar life habits of these so-called “Christians” as they were so unique. This fascinating piece of literature by this unknown author captured how these early Christians **lived in the world but not of the world**. This manuscript survived until it was destroyed in a fire in 1870 in Strasbourg.

Remember, the following writing is from the second century and discusses the life of Christians. “Christians are indistinguishable from other men, neither by nationality, language, or customs. They do not inhabit separate cities of their own or speak a strange dialect, or follow some outlandish way of life. Their teaching is not based upon reveries inspired by the curiosity of men. Unlike some other people, they champion no purely human doctrine. About dress, food and manner of life in general, they follow the customs of whatever city they happen to be living in, whether it is Greek or foreign.

And yet, there is something extraordinary about their lives. **They live in their own countries as though they are only passing through.** They play their full role as citizens but labor under all the disabilities of aliens. **Any country can be their homeland, but their homeland, wherever it may be, is a foreign country.** Like others, they marry and have children, but they do not expose them. They share meals, but not their wives.

They live in the flesh, but they are not governed by the desires of the flesh. They pass their days upon earth, but they are citizens of heaven. Obedient to the laws, yet they live on a level that transcends the law. Christians love all men, but all men persecute them; condemned because they are not understood, they are put to death but raised to life again. They live in poverty but enrich many; they are totally destitute but possess an abundance of everything.

They suffer dishonor, but that is their glory. They are defamed but vindicated. A blessing is their answer to abuse, and deference is their response to insult. For the good they do they receive the punishment of malefactors, but even then, they rejoice, as though receiving the gift of life. They are attacked by the Jews as aliens, they are persecuted by the Greeks, yet no one can explain the reason for the hatred.

To speak in general terms, we may say that the Christian is to the world what the soul is to the body. As the soul is present in every part of the body, while remaining distinct from it, **so Christians are found in all the cities of the world, but cannot be identified with the world.**

As the visible body contained the invisible soul, so Christians are seen living in the world, but their religious life remains unseen. The body hates the soul and wars against it, not because of any injury the soul has done it, but because of the restriction the soul places on its pleasures. Similarly, the world hates the Christians, not because they have done it any wrong, but because they are opposed to its enjoyment.

Christians love those who hate them just as the soul loves the body and all its members despite the body’s hatred.

The soul, though immortal, has a mortal dwelling place; and Christians also live for a time amidst perishable things, while awaiting the freedoms from change and decay that will be theirs in heaven.”

We would all do well as a society if we shared the same testimony that this **second-century** eyewitness recorded in his letter to Diognetus.

The Bible is full of admonitions that we should not fall in love with the world, which simply means the cosmos or the world system. We must fall in love with heaven and live as citizens of heaven.

"Do not love the world or the things in the world. If anyone loves the world, the love of the Father is not in him. For all that is in the world—the lust of the flesh, the lust of the eyes, and the pride of life—is not of the Father but is of the world. And the world is passing away, and the lust of it; but he who does the will of God abides forever" (1 John 2:15-17, NKJV).

A soul needs to be careful about opening the door to sin. Don't open the door of lust, even a crack! I like the lyrics of a well-known song, Sin Will Take You Farther by The Cathedrals, the chorus warns,

"Sin will take you farther than you want to go,
Slowly, but wholly, taking control,
Sin will leave you longer than you want to stay,
Sin will cost you far more than you want to pay."

What can we do to avoid sin?

The answer is as simple as the lyrics of a child's song:

Oh, be careful little eyes what you see,
Oh, be careful little eyes what you see,
For the Father up above is looking down in love,
So be careful little eyes what you see.

Oh, be careful little ears what you hear.
Oh, be careful little tongue what you say.
Oh, be careful little hands what you do.
Oh, be careful little feet where you go.
Oh, be careful little heart whom you trust.
Oh, be careful little mind what you think. — Unknown

Let us all strive to live as citizens of heaven! ✝

FIT FOR PURPOSE

JUNIOR THOMPSON

"Break me and melt me till I'm nothing.
Mold me and shape me till I'm something.
Then take me and use me for your glory,
Until all that I am is YOU."

I wish to use a term that businesses seem to have adopted over the last few years. It has become a guiding factor in their hiring processes: 'Fit for purpose.' According to the English dictionary, it means that one is well-equipped or well-suited for its designated role or purpose.

Today, companies are using this term more and more, perhaps because in the past they hired persons who may have seemed to have the right qualifications but did not necessarily have the right skills or attitude for the job. Many companies have grappled with this issue and have decided to not necessarily ask much about one's work experience. Instead, when conducting interviews for recruiting new personnel they want to know more about you as a person; who you are, and what you represent.

You would be amazed to learn some of the reasons why certain people were not selected for a job, even though they were fully qualified academically.

Before I continue, I wish to clearly state that God does not make mistakes. Once you are called of God, we are 'fit for purpose.' Romans 8:30, *"Moreover whom He did predestinate, them He also called: and whom He called: them He also justified: and whom He justified, them He also glorified"* (KJV). I wish to add another caveat here: Romans 11:29, *"For God's gifts and His call are irrevocable"* (NIV). John 17:22, *"I have given them the glory that You gave Me, that they may be one as We are one"* (NIV). What Jesus Christ did through His death and resurrection is to put us in right standing with God. Hallelujah!

However, we can disqualify ourselves from being 'fit for purpose' when

we allow other spirits to influence our hearts instead of just the Holy Spirit.

I take notice of the fact that companies are now making a full turnaround, coming back to the basic tenets of employees having a heart in what they are doing, and not just making it a job.

We, ourselves, can become slaves to church—just making sure that we attend all the Sunday morning services, but not truly recognizing the full extent of where God wants to take us. We may not fully let go and let God. *"Having a form of godliness, but denying the power thereof"* (2 Timothy 3:5, KJV).

When the apostle Paul wrote in 1 Corinthians 11:29 of people not discerning the Lord's body as it relates to partaking in communion, he was indicating that when we partake unworthily, we do not fully understand why Jesus Christ was crucified, and that can be another message in itself. Glory be to God!

Romans 14:17, *"For the kingdom of God is not meat and drink; but righteousness, peace, and joy in the Holy Ghost"* (KJV).

I thank God that in His kingdom we are no longer under the law which means we must work to gain God's approval and acceptance by keeping all the points of the law. Rather we are under grace which means God has put His laws in our heart through the indwelling of His Holy Spirit who enables us by His grace to fulfil the righteous requirements of the law as we walk by His leading.

In Romans 12:1-2, our brother Paul appeals to our sense of spiritual reasoning:

"I beseech you therefore, brethren, by the mercies of God, that ye present your bodies a living sacrifice, holy, acceptable unto God, which is your reasonable service. And be not conformed to this world: but be ye

transformed by the renewing of your mind, that ye may prove what is that good, and acceptable, and perfect will of God” (KJV).

You see, saints, God is the one who calls His elect. Matthew 22:14 says, *“For many are called, but few are chosen.”* (KJV). You, me, and the many others whom God has called are the chosen of God. Once we are called of God and citizens of the kingdom, we are living stones.

1 Peter 2:5 (KJV), *“Ye also, as lively stones, are built up a spiritual house, an holy priesthood, to offer up spiritual sacrifices, acceptable to God by Jesus Christ”* (approved by Jesus Christ).

“There is therefore now no condemnation to them which are in Christ Jesus, who walk not after the flesh, but after the Spirit” (Romans 8:1).

Over the years, many of us have had hands laid upon us by the presbytery and various ministries, confirming and sometimes highlighting our gifts and ministries.

1 Corinthians 12 provides us with an understanding of our spiritual gifts and highlights that there are diversities of gifts.

In 2 Timothy 1:6, we are encouraged to stir up the gift of God within us. 1 Timothy 4:14, *“Neglect not the gift that is in thee, which was given thee by prophecy, with the laying on of hands of the presbytery”* (KJV).

All of these gifts make up the whole spiritual being that God wants to use in tremendous ways to perform His works here on earth.

So the phrase ‘fit for purpose’ came about as a new approach taken by companies to have the right person on board to contribute to the development of the goals of that particular company. However, it is very important to note that the company must first decide what its long-term goals are and how they plan to achieve them.

In the kingdom of God, we already know our goal: to walk by God’s Holy Spirit at all times—in other words, to walk softly and circumspectly with God. Romans 8:14 says, *“For as many as are led by the Spirit of God, they are the sons of God”* (KJV).

So I thank Almighty God that we are a people led by His Holy Spirit, and as we develop our gifts and ministries, we are then fitted by God into the place where He desires us to contribute to His kingdom.

Proverbs 18:16 tells us, *“A man’s gift makes room for him, and brings him before great men”* (NKJV). Although this is not our aim, the wonderful God we serve allows us to achieve earthly accomplishments that can only be possible through heavenly intervention.

In other words, once we remain under the grace of God and allow our gifts and ministries to develop, we too will be amazed at where God takes us. And it’s not because this is our focus, but like our brother Paul, we continue to *“press toward the mark for the prize of the high calling of God in Christ Jesus”* (Philippians 3:14, KJV).

Our focus is not on worldly things; it is on God.

There’s a part of a song that says, “Of things I’ve had my fill, but yet I hunger still for more of You.”

Yes, brethren, there must always be a yearning and a hunger for more of God. We must continue to strive for the excellency that is in Christ Jesus.

Philippians 3:8, *“Yea doubtless, and I count all things but loss for the excellency of the knowledge of Christ Jesus my Lord: for whom I have suffered the loss of all things, and do count them but dung, that I may win Christ”* (KJV).

In conclusion:

Being ‘fit for purpose’ simply means walking by God’s Holy Spirit, which is also by faith. We are all a part of that wonderful building built without hands. To use a line from a song our brother Crafton Lewis sang: “Every stone is fitted in its proper place, not determined by you or me, but fitted by His grace.”

My Lord! What a wonderful place to be, knowing that we are making ourselves available to God, with the help of His Holy Spirit, so that He can make us all individually and collectively ‘fit for purpose’.

God is so good. God bless you all. ✝

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